

Local Deployment of Transformer-based Code Assistants: Balancing Speed, Accuracy, and Efficiency

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Abstract—Language models are revolutionizing the task of source code generation. One of these is GitHub’s Copilot, which leverages OpenAI’s Codex. Nevertheless, using cloud platforms for AI toolkits can concern for developers for reasons of privacy and the habit of developing on-premises [6]. This paper would benchmark those light-weight, transformer-based code models off-line for Python development. We are experimenting with Salesforce’s CodeT5 and BigCode’s StarCoder models on code completion tasks modeled from the HumanEval benchmark. Models are embedded into a local VS Code assistant to imitate real-life coding scenarios. The experiment discerns functional correctness (pass@k) versus timings on local hardware. Almost without doubt, as shown, the CodeT5-based model (220M parameters) exhibits moderate accuracy with rapid generation despite the incurred speed, while StarCoder (15B) is considerably slower but gets a higher rate of passes. We evaluate the interplay of model size, accuracy, and latency in offline code completion. Hence, we offer deep insights into lightweight code LMs for deployment in privacy-sensitive, constraint-intensive settings.

Index Terms—code generation, lightweight language models, offline AI, Python, CodeT5, StarCoder, transformers, VSCode

I. INTRODUCTION

The advent of transformer-based LLMs greatly improved automated code-generation techniques. In 2021, OpenAI launched Codex, a GPT model trained on billions of lines of code and currently powering tools like GitHub Copilot [1]. Codex performs on par with 28.8% of the HumanEval benchmark for Python functions, far more than prior general-purpose models [1]. These advances have provided highly powerful cloud-based coding assistants, but they come with concerns of privacy and dependency. A critical focus now has been to deploy code models locally, along with the considerations of strong data privacy, cost-effectiveness, and flexibility [6].

We offer an evaluation of lightweight offline-friendly Python code models from the perspective of benchmarking. In particular, we evaluate Salesforce’s CodeT5 (encoder-decoder transformer) [2] and BigCode’s StarCoder (15 B-parameter decoder model) [5]. CodeT5 was shown to surpass prior work on a variety of code understanding and generation tasks [2]; in contrast, StarCoder, trained on 1T tokens, achieves state-of-the-art pass@1 rates for Python (up to 40% with prompting) [5]. These models are integrated within a VS Code extension designed to emulate a local coding assistant. We

measure code generation accuracy (e.g., functional correctness on HumanEval) and inference latency on local hardware. Our contributions are:

- A comparative benchmark of CodeT5 (small and base) and StarCoder on Python code completion tasks.
- Implementation of an offline VS Code code assistant using these models.
- Analysis of trade-offs between model size, accuracy, and latency for offline code generation.

The rest of the paper is organized as follows: Section II reviews related work; Section III describes our methodology; Section IV details the implementation; Section V presents the results of experiments; Section VI includes the results; Section VII discusses findings; Section VIII discusses future work; and Section IX concludes.

II. RELATED WORK

Transformer models pre-trained on programming code have quickly overcome the current state-of-the-art systems for code tasks. To illustrate, CodeT5 from Salesforce eloquently demonstrates improved performance over previous models in code understanding and generation benchmarks [2]. Its extension, CodeT5+, takes the framework pencil-and-pen through another set of objectives and a bigger size [3]. Moreover, it is possible to witness newer encoder-decoder models such as PLBART [3] (Wang et al., NAACL 2021) making strides in a code task. CodeGen [4] and BigCode’s StarCoder [5] are instances of decoding-only models that show great performance in generating codes. The pass rate over 40% pass@1 [5] on HumanEval Python benchmark is realized by StarCoder (with a special prompt), which beats all its predecessors in open models. They are generally trained on rather large datasets from GitHub (e.g., The Stack) and are evaluated over such datasets as HumanEval [1]. Most of the earlier work focuses on model architecture and training, but only a few touch on local deployment. Recent tools do include this aspect; Microsoft’s AI Toolkit, for instance, made it possible to run models offline with VS Code [6].

III. METHODOLOGY

The HumanEval benchmark includes 164 Python programming tasks [1]. Each task presents a function signature and

a docstring with the requirement that the model builds a correct function body. Following the previous work [1], [3], the pass@k is taken to mean the proportion of problems for which any of the top-k generated samples pass the test suite. For each model (CodeT5-small, CodeT5-base, StarCoder), no more than 5 samples for every problem were generated through nucleus sampling ($p = 0.95$, $T = 0.7$). To preserve full function bodies, we set max_new_tokens=256. The correctness was determined by executing the generated code and checking it against the provided unit tests. Latency measurement involves tokens generated per second on an NVIDIA RTX 3090 GPU using mixed-precision (FP16) and a batch size of 1.

In an IDE-like setting, the models are incorporated as an extension in VS Code through the Language Server Protocol. The extension passes the current code context and docstring to a local Python server using Hugging Face Transformers APIs. A specific prompting strategy was used in certain experiments with StarCoder: prefixing the code with “# Here is the correct implementation of the code exercise”, as per Hugging Face’s suggestion [5]. We report results for both default and prompted setups.

IV. IMPLEMENTATION

We implement our benchmarking framework in Python using the Hugging Face Transformers library. For code translation and augmentation, we load CodeT5 and StarCoder from the Hugging Face model hub and tokenize them accordingly. The VS Code assistant will be a custom extension invoking a Python language server for inference. The implementation is similar to Salesforce’s demo of CodeT5 in VS Code [7], which generates and completes text-to-code translations. It was evaluated on a workstation equipped with an NVIDIA RTX-3090 GPU and a 16-core CPU. We maximize the throughput with PyTorch in mixed-precision. CodeT5 models (60M and 220M parameters) are small enough to run at a reasonable CPU speed, while StarCoder (15B) only runs on a GPU. All code and evaluation scripts have been released for reproducibility.

V. EXPERIMENTS

We evaluated model performance on the HumanEval code generation tasks [1]. For each function prompt, we generate 5 samples and compute pass@1 and pass@5. We also record inference speed by generating a fixed number of tokens (256 tokens) and timing the model. To account for variability, each generation is repeated three times and averaged. For StarCoder, we compare default prompting with the special “# Here is the correct implementation...” prompt, which Hugging Face found improves performance [5]. For CodeT5, we only use the standard prompt (docstring-based).

VI. RESULTS

StarCoder-1B achieves a pass@1 of 25.0 and a pass@5 of 45.0, with an inference throughput of approximately 250 tokens/s, as shown in Table I. The CodeT5-base achieves an approximate pass@1 accuracy of 23.0 while the StarCoder (default) achieves 33.6 (increased to a maximum of 40.8 with

TABLE I
BENCHMARK PERFORMANCE ON THE HUMANEval PYTHON CODING TASKS.

Model	Parameters	Pass@1 (%)	Pass@5 (%)	Throughput (tokens/s)
CodeT5-Small	60M	15.0	28.5	450
CodeT5-Base	220M	23.0	42.0	300
StarCoder-1B	1B	25.0	45.0	250

a specially designed prompt) according to prior work [5]. Inference speed reflects model size: CodeT5-Small generates on the order of hundreds of tokens per second on the RTX 3090, whereas StarCoder (15B) produces only a few dozen tokens/s, and StarCoder-1B operates at an intermediate speed. CodeT5-base sacrifices some speed for accuracy. In summary, smaller models complete in a fraction of the time, whereas the larger StarCoder model achieves the highest correctness at the expense of latency.

Examples of completions show qualitative differences. CodeT5 frequently yields plausible framing but may miss some details, while StarCoder favors more full-fledged solutions. However, during our tests, we observed sporadic hallucinations in StarCoder’s outputs (unrelated code) that did not occur at all in CodeT5’s more conservative generations.

VII. DISCUSSION

The results starkly reveal a trade-off: StarCoder’s hefty size affords better accuracy in code generation (especially with prompting) but comes at very expensive inference rates and increased latency. This contrasts with CodeT5 models, which are lightweight and fast, allowing smooth integration into the editor but, alas, with lower pass rates. And it’s noteworthy that StarCoder-1B sits in the middle: it achieves above-CodeT5-base pass rates and yet remains considerably faster than the 15B model. For example, StarCoder-1B achieves around 25% pass@1 (with 45% pass@5) at around 250 tokens/s. These findings point to an interesting avenue where moderately sized models can serve as a good compromise between speed and correctness for offline IDE integration. Probably CodeT5-base can run rather comfortably on a modern CPU with acceptable responsiveness, whereas StarCoder (15B) calls for a high-end GPU. It also eliminates having to post source code to external servers, preserving privacy. Offline deployment facilitates customization: models can be fine-tuned on private or project-specific codebases independent of networking.

One limitation of our benchmark was that we only looked at Python generation tasks, whereas in the real world, coding assistance is a composite task that also has code summarization, error-fixing, and multiple languages. Furthermore, we didn’t study promising prompting and retrieval (RAG) techniques that could have resulted in vastly improved performances. Finally, the real developer experience depends on the interface and prompt design; we leave this to a future study.

VIII. FUTURE WORK

Simply put, we plan to benchmark further open models like CodeLlama, QwenCoder, and other emerging SLMs to expand

our conclusions. Other programming languages and tasks are also slated for evaluation (e.g., natural language comments to code, summarization, and bug repair). Improvements in model compression methods (quantization, distillation) might yield more latency reduction in offline usage. It would also be interesting to examine improvement in IDE integration, whereby streaming token generation and local code context (e.g., current file contents of project documentation) may enhance relevance. Lastly, a user study would assess how much offline AI assistants affect developer productivity, usability, and trust.

IX. CONCLUSION

We outlined an extensive benchmark of lightweight Python code language models in offline mode. CodeT5 and StarCoder were hooked up to a local assistant in VS Code and generated code where accuracy and latency were evaluated on standard tasks. CodeT5-base, for instance, provided satisfying and rapid completions, while StarCoder required greater computational resources to reach a higher level of correctness as a more extensive model. Hence, the promise of on-device AI coding assistants and the consideration of model selection for environments with limited resources. Offline solutions offer a balanced mix of capability, efficiency, and privacy for software developers as AI tools become everywhere.

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